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a stomach for a fight, even with their backs against the wall.

The 'Gabba Miracle' of 2021, conjured by an injury-ridden Indian side, ended a 32-year Australian hegemony in Brisbane, emboldening even the modern-day laggard West Indies to repeat the feat last year.

Following that triumph, India dared to dream and will take a cue from it when the series opens on a bouncy track in Perth. The absence of skipper Rohit Sharma and Shubman Gill for the first Test, though unfortunate, will perhaps only feed into the recent template of overcoming adversity Down Under.

But one can't sit on its laurels and hope for history to repeat itself. The Indian brigade in transition will rely on a blend of youth and experience in its quest to challenge the world Test champion.

Virat Kohli, India's top run-scorer in the 2011-12 and 2014-15 Border-Gavaskar Trophy (BGT) in Australia, is deemed vital, but without contributions from the likes of Yashasvi Jaiswal, Gill, and Rishabh Pant, the Indian challenge will fall flat, like it did in the series mentioned above.

The last time India toured Australia for the BGT, it showed that setting the tone isn't the be-all and end-all in the longest format, bouncing back from the ignominy of being skittled for 36 in the first Test in Adelaide to script history.

Thus, with injury and unavailability forcing India to shuffle the batting order in Perth, the visitor would know better than to brood over the first Test's outcome. The opening contest will provide Jaiswal with a new opening partner, which could see an under-fire KL Rahul return to the spot he has batted at for the bulk of his stop-start career, or prolific domestic run accumulator Abhimanyu Easwaran handed a debut cap despite a string of poor scores against Australia 'A'. Meanwhile, Dhruv Jurel, who scored 80 and 68 in the second game against Australia 'A' and showcased his affinity for playing on bouncy tracks, could fill in for Gill at No. 3.

In the face of a somewhat new-look Indian line-up, the team might, at some point in the series, rue the void left by crisis men Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane, who have been the architects of the last two series wins Down Under.

Pujara's ability to get under the skin of the Aussies with his doughty spirit and Rahane's technical genius are undoubtedly in short supply in the current setup. Jaiswal, Gill, and Sarfaraz Khan may need to curb some of their natural stroke-making instinct in challenging conditions and even put their bodies on the line.

In contrast, Australia will tuck into home comforts with most of its Test mainstays still in the fray. Usman Khawaja, Steve Smith, and Marnus Labuschagne

